



Samsung Galaxy Buds Pro

Leaked promotional video gives a clearer look at the rumoured ANC-based wireless earbuds. <http://digit.in/jan21-51>



AirPods Pro 2 Through-body

Leak reveals users will be able to control their earbuds by touching their face or making in-air hand gestures. <http://digit.in/jan21-52>

Zebronics Zeb-Juke Bar 9700 Pro

How good is Dolby Atmos on a budget soundbar?

Budget TVs today come with a host of options like HDMI ARC, 4K HDR playback and some smart capabilities. Some budget TVs also boast of support for Dolby Atmos as well. One of the compromises made to keep the price of these TVs low is the quality of audio output. The 20W to 40 W of sound output from most budget TVs can get the job done for watching regular TVs but for an immersive experience, you need to invest in a sound system like a soundbar. Not only does the Zebronics Zeb-Juke Bar 9700 Pro boast of Dolby Atmos support, but also has upward-firing drivers to simulate the height channels.

Build and Design

The Zeb-Juke Bar 9700 Pro has a simple traditional soundbar design. It has a plastic body with a grill occupying the front and the top of the soundbar. It has a hint of silver on the sides which is nice as this will ensure people will notice it. It has two rubber feet which hold it well when kept on a table. The soundbar itself is relatively light but does not feel flimsy. The left of the front has the Zebronics logo and the right has the Dolby Atmos badge. At the centre, we have an LED indicator to show you the sound preset, the current source, etc. We wish this were a little dimmer or would automatically go off after some time as its constant visibility can get distracting, especially if you watch content in a pitch-dark room. The top of the soundbar has physical buttons for power, source and volume. Moving over to the subwoofer, it has a rectangular form factor with the duct facing front and at the bottom half of the soundbar as we have seen on so many other subwoofers.



Price
₹7,999

Ports and Connectivity

Speaking of connectivity options, the speaker has one HDMI ARC port and two HDMI pass-through ports capable of 4K with HDR. It also has an Optical in, one USB port, Bluetooth 5.0 and one AUX-In. All the ports are neatly hidden at the back of the soundbar and easily accessible. We didn't wall-mount the soundbar, so we can't say for sure, but it may be a bit of trouble to manage cables when wall-mounting the soundbar.

Moving to the remote control, it is all plastic with curved edges to add to the grip. It runs on two AAA batteries and offers playback controls for Bluetooth and USB connectivity, four different EQ presets, treble, bass and volume controls and the ability to change inputs.

Performance

Bass-heavy is the first thing that will come to your mind when you hear this soundbar. Be it for movies, TV shows or music, the soundbar has an overemphasis on bass. The soundbar can get really loud too, if bringing the house down is something you want. If you connect a Dolby Atmos enabled source to the soundbar and

connect the soundbar to your TV via ARC, you will be able to enjoy the Atmos encoding from the source even if your TV doesn't support it, which is good. Let's get the Dolby Atmos performance out of the way. While the soundbar has decent channel separation, don't expect the sound to come from above you. It has a decently wide soundstage but gimmicky Atmos performance. At about 30 to 40 per cent volume, the soundbar can get pretty loud but

what it lacks is clarity and that is again because of the bass-heavy signature of the bar. Watching news or TV shows where dialogue is most important, you still get a bass-heavy sound output. The only preset that worked to reduce this was the news preset.



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Verdict

What the Zebronics Zeb-Juke Bar 9700 Pro Dolby Atmos Soundbar has going for it is good connectivity options, a simple plug and play setup and support for Dolby Atmos decoding. While the Dolby Atmos performance is gimmicky, the bass heavy nature of the soundbar makes it hard to recommend for all. If you don't want the additional HDMI pass-through ports and are looking for a surround sound experience, you can check out the similarly priced Sony HT-S20R. It is a 5.1 soundbar with dedicated surround speakers and has better overall sound output.

—Sameer Mitha

SPECIFICATIONS

SUBWOOFER: 150 W | SOUNDBAR: 300 W | FREQ. RESPONSE: 45 Hz - 20 kHz | BLUETOOTH: 5.0 | INPUT: 3.5 mm, Optical, HDMI (ARC), HDMI | WEIGHT: 8.2 kg.

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